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INFORMATION ETHICS

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Faculty of Engineering,
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Fakulteit Ingenieurswese, Bou-omgewing en
Inligtingtegnologie / Lefapha la Boetsenere,
Tikologo ya Kago le Theknolotši ya Tshedimošo



IE and virtual worlds – a case of second life

Presented by Dr Brenda van Wyk

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Essential readings

- Second Life founder Philip Rosedale calls generative AI an 'Alien Intelligence' lacking human reasoning
- <https://www.businesstoday.in/technology/news/story/second-life-founder-philip-rosedale-calls-generative-ai-an-alien-intelligence-lacking-human-reasoning-376613-2023-04-08>
- SL Official website- <https://secondlife.com/>
- The role of avatar in the metavers: <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/role-avatar-metaverse-metaspaces-metaverse/>



Outcomes

After completing this session you will be able to:

- Critically discuss and account for information ethics in the virtual world
- Use a case study to explain the nature of IE in the metaverse and related concepts



Overview

- Introduction
- Background
- Discussion of key concepts related to IE in SL:



In sum, information ethics is a dynamic and evolving field, flowing from various disciplines and perspectives and cultures, critical in these times of intercultural exchange and dialog.

- Thomas Froehlich

Information Ethics

Scholars and practitioners of Information Ethics draw a distinction between:

- Morals: customs and traditions
- Ethics: critical reflection on morals
- Law: norms formally approved by state power or international political bodies.



The Infosphere (Floridi)

- The Infosphere is a term coined in the seventies, used in the field of Information Ethics to describe a collection of inforgs and how they interact with each other
- Luciano Floridi defines the Infosphere as:
"the whole informational environment constituted by all informational entities (thus including informational agents as well), their properties, interactions, processes and mutual relations"
- An inforg is an informationally embodied organism, entity made up of information, that exists in the infosphere - also called natural agents
- SL falls here



Infosphere

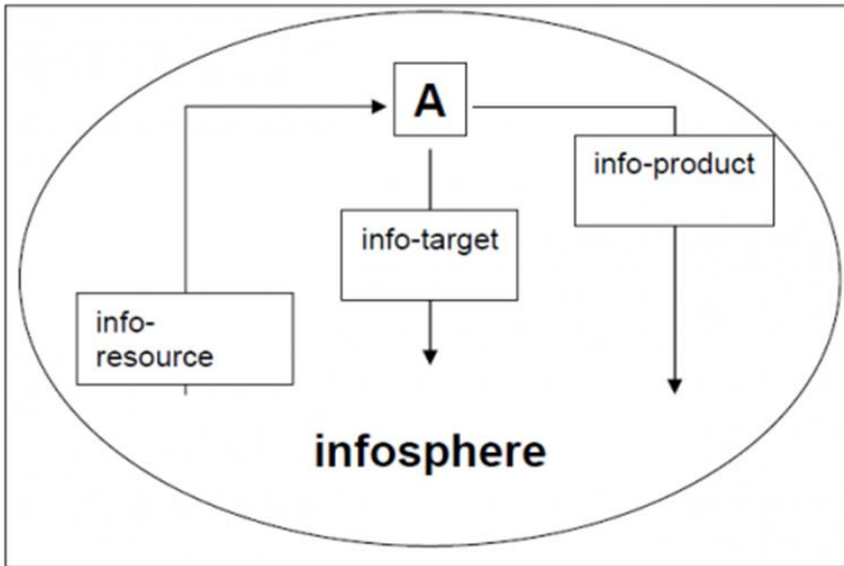
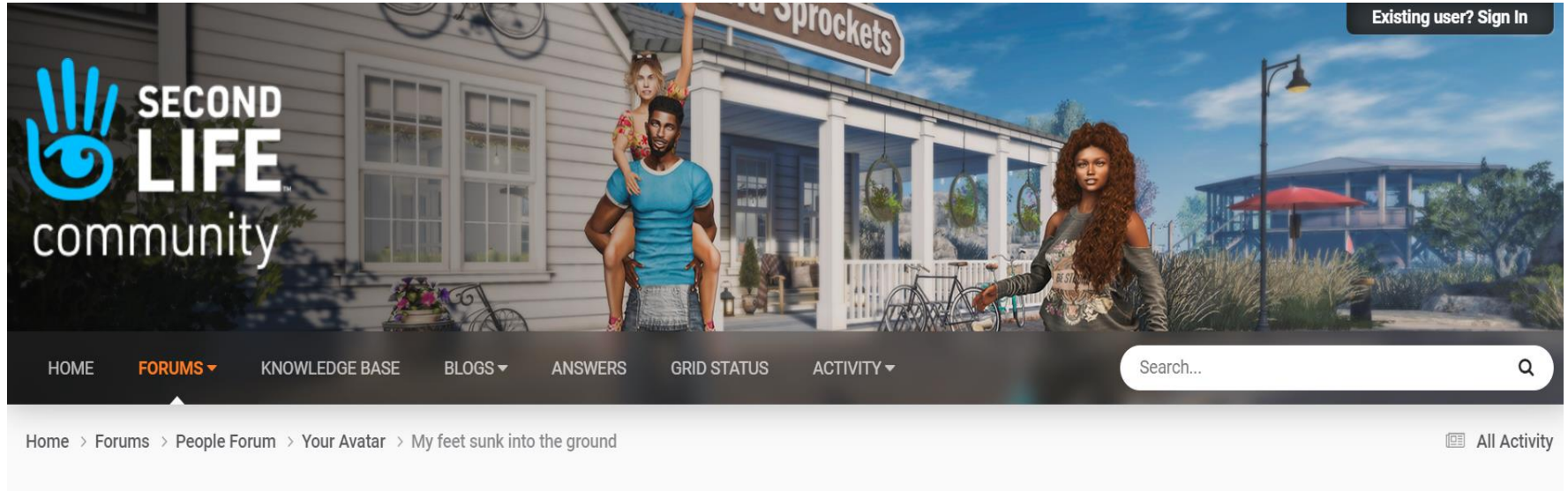


Figure 2 The “Internal” R(esource) P(roduct) T(arget) Model

The case of Second Life



Introduction

- Information ethics is concerned with the ethical and moral codes governing human conduct. This is sufficient when dealing with first and second order technologies, since these require human initiation, participation, and oversight, but what about third order, re-ontologising technologies? Can moral agency be sustained without ongoing human presence, and if not, how does this affect well-being across the individual, social, and signification domains?
- These three domains—the individual, the social, and signification— are inextricably intertwined with one another. Individuals occupy social worlds and interact with one another through the mediation of signification. Conversely, the domain of the social is the context within which individuals live, exchange information, and engage with each other through signification and representational practices.

Background

What is Second Life?

- Linden Lab is the company that created the platform
- They say their creation is not a game - Catherine Smith. “It’s an entirely open-ended experience.”
- Second Life does bear some resemblance to the “Sim City” and “Sims” franchises from Maxis and Electronic Arts
- Players build and design a city in “Sim City,” and in “The Sims,” players control characters in day-to-day activities. There are no monsters to kill, no real objective to speak of. But the grow-your-own quality of these games resonated with players
- “The Sims” is the best-selling PC game of all time
- Second Life is also compared to Blizzard Entertainment’s “World of Warcraft.” Unless you’ve been living under a rock, you’ve undoubtedly heard about this record-breaking massively multiplayer online role-playing game



Concepts

Moral agency

Information
domains

Information
ethics

Virtual
information
ethics

Information
grounds

Small world

Cyberbullying,
griefing in
Second Life

Metaverse

Collaborative
information
behaviour

MMORPG

-
- Average of 60,000 + users per day.
 - Meetings, conferences, research, projects, career exploration, practica, and projects are conducted.
 - A sizable number of users are outside the United States (Steel, 2006) - transcultural



The interactive virtual world contains metaverses - differs from other types of games

The metaverse is a dynamic, open and interoperable space, much like the internet but in 3D

Second Life (SL) is a 3D virtual environment in which users are, by default, represented by a human avatar of their choice

- Seamless world, consistent – continue when player leaves
- User has ownership of content
- Scale and complexity more advanced
- Growing economy of buying and selling
- Dynamic, constantly changing environment



The psychology of avatars, chatbots and virtual assistants

Avatars play a pivotal role in shaping social interactions in the shared space known to us as the metaverse; creating a sense of presence and individuality is important, and avatars serve this purpose:

- Digital depiction of self
- Physical and digital realms well-connected

Griefing in SL

A griefer or bad-faith player is a player in a multiplayer video game who deliberately irritates and harasses other players within the game, by using aspects of the game in unintended ways, such as destroying something another player made or built

The “residents” – user-initiated actions

- There are many unethical and illegal behaviors that take place in SL
- Some of these behaviors, including copyright infringement
- No fear of consequences



Some of the unethical behaviours of SL

- Illegal file-sharing (copyright infringement)
- Spamming,
- multiple identities,
- identity deception
- illicit materials
- breach in privacy, monitoring and eavesdropping,
- confidentiality and proprietary information, to crimes, such as harassment, vandalism and unauthorized use of computer information, such as passwords, and intellectual property and trademark infringements



But it is just a game ?

- In many ways, Second Life is similar to massively multiplayer online role playing games (**MMORPGs**)
- Like an MMORPG, users represent themselves with a customizable, 3D figure that acts like a computer-generated puppet.
- Users navigate through an online world, encountering strange landscapes and new people. Unlike MMORPGs, residents in Second Life aren't in a game, though there are games inside Second Life's virtual environment.
- They inhabit a virtual world free of pre-determined goals or tasks, just like the real world.
- Video game rating system



Is Second Life still “A Thing”?

- Second Life is a 3-D online virtual world where avatars are created by multi online line players and conduct how real people do in real life:
- Buy stuff. Sell stuff. Gamble. Listen to music. Buy property. Flirt. Play games. Watch movies. Have sex.
- But is it a game?
- User-centered content – “resident” build the content
- Role plat



Second Life as an Information Ground (theory by Fisher, 1990)

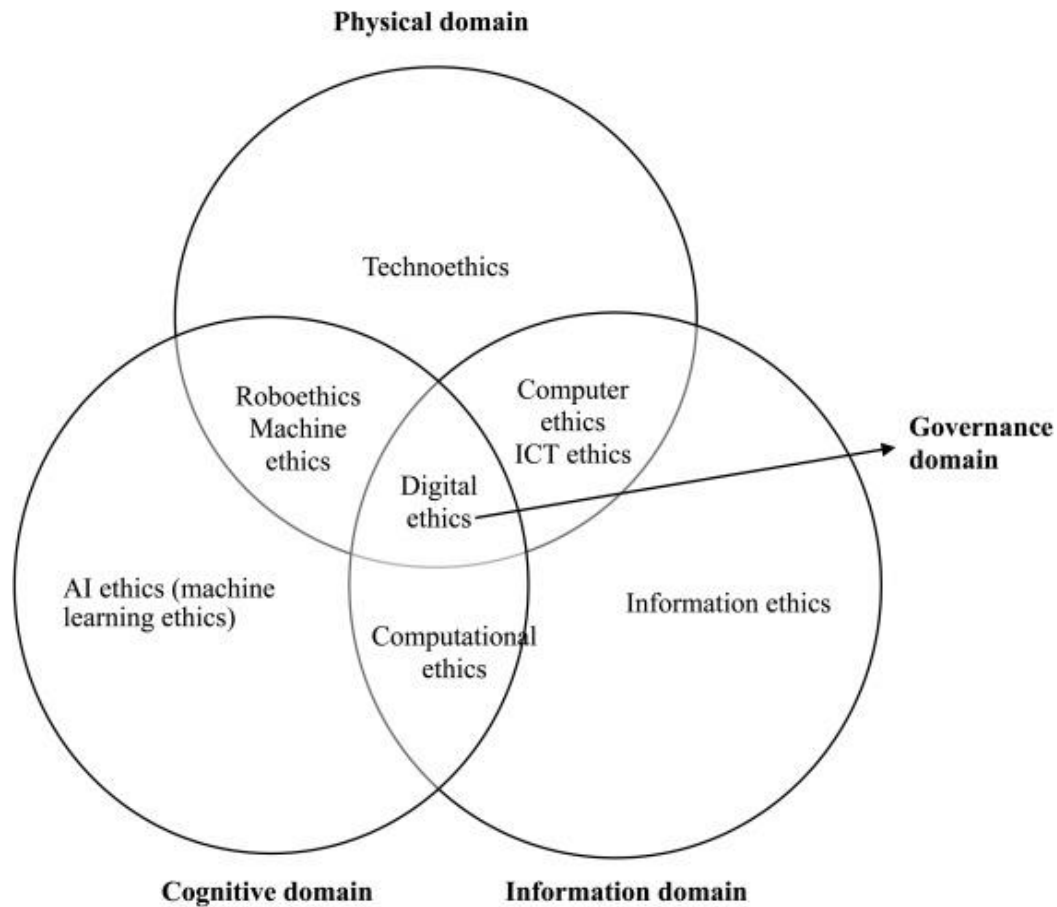
- An Information Ground is an environment temporarily created when people come together for a singular purpose but from whose behavior emerges a social atmosphere that fosters the spontaneous and serendipitous sharing of information
- Implications for Collaborative Information Behavior



Information domains

- Concept of small worlds – Chatman
- A three-part concept for information sharing, independent of, and across information systems and security domains that
 - 1) identifies information sharing participants as individual members,
 - 2) contains shared information objects, and
 - 3) provides a security policy that identifies the roles and privileges of the members and the protections required for the information objects.





Small worlds

- Chatman popularized the concept of the small world in developing her theories in information behavior research.
- A small world describes a world where the members share similar opinions and concerns, and understand each other because of the customs and language they uniquely share
- Information is socially constructed in the group - Will not seek information outside group
- <https://images.app.goo.gl/pebdadx9MthxyL2F9>





Social domain

- The contextual and the social dimensions of information use
- Individuals do not exist in isolation, but are situated in social contexts, influenced by the realities of those contexts
- As Dervin notes, *'there is a mandate to build conceptual system which would provide guidance'* ([Dervin, 1997](#), p. 15) for considering the role of context in information activities



Information ethics in a digital /virtual setting

- Information ethics explores the relationship between the creation, organization, dissemination, and use of information, and the ethical standards and moral codes governing human conduct
- The technologies we use to facilitate and empower our individual information behaviours are signifiers in both the individual and the social domains, and may have lasting ethical consequences
- Floridi ([2017](#)) characterizes this as “*digital’s cleaving power*”, or the power to couple, decouple, and recouple the world.



Information ethics and Metaverse

Metaverse code of ethics

1. Show respect
2. Tell the truth
3. Do no harm
4. Show concern
5. Work for good
6. Show tolerance
7. Respect privacy

Ethics problems

- Privacy
- Ownership
- Control

Privacy vs. pseudonymity

- Many users may prefer to use pseudonyms within the metaverse
- Privacy concerns if their real-world identities can be linked to their virtual ones



Ownership problems

- Intellectual property rights: involves the creation and distribution of a vast amount of digital content e.g digital art - who owns the rights to this content and how it can be protected?
- Virtual property rights: Individuals in virtual worlds have the right to own virtual property, including buildings, land and enterprises
- Jurisdiction: In cases involving virtual property and intellectual property rights, it can be difficult to decide what laws should be applied because the metaverse is spread out across many different nations and territories
- Contractual issues: concerns about the enforceability of agreements signed between people for the sale and transfer of goods

Oversight and monitoring

- Film board
- End user agreements

SL, AI and the Turing Test

The Turing Test was proposed in a paper published in 1950 by mathematician and computing pioneer Alan Turing.

- “American entrepreneur Philip Rosedale, the founder of Linden Lab, the technology company known for developing Second Life, has compared generative artificial intelligence (AI) like ChatGPT to an "alien intelligence" capable of superhuman tasks **but lacking human-like reasoning.**”
- 2023: “The Turing Test is a deceptively simple method of determining whether a machine can demonstrate human intelligence: If a machine can engage in a conversation with a human without being detected as a machine, **it has demonstrated human intelligence.**”

Turing Test:

During the Turing Test, the human interrogator asks several questions to both players. Based on the answers, the interrogator attempts to determine which player is a computer and which player is a human respondent.

Player A
Computer



Player B

**Human
Responder**



Player C

Interrogator



■ Question to Respondents

■ Answers to Question

Video Turing Test

<http://abcnews.go.com/live/video/special-live-11>

Self study

Can Avatars pass the Turing test?

Richard L. Gilbert, Andrew Forney,

Can avatars pass the Turing test? Intelligent agent perception in a 3D virtual environment,
International Journal of Human-Computer Studies, Volume 73, 2015, Pages 30-36,

ISSN 1071-5819,

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijhcs.2014.08.001>

Conclusion

- Social media systems such as Second Life, Facebook, and instant messaging are designed with social interaction as one of the primary functionalities for users.
- Information grounds can form in any of these social media, and can lead to collaborative information behavior
- In order to support such collaborative information behavior, social media systems need to be designed to address awareness, common ground, and information fragmentation
- IE ethics



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